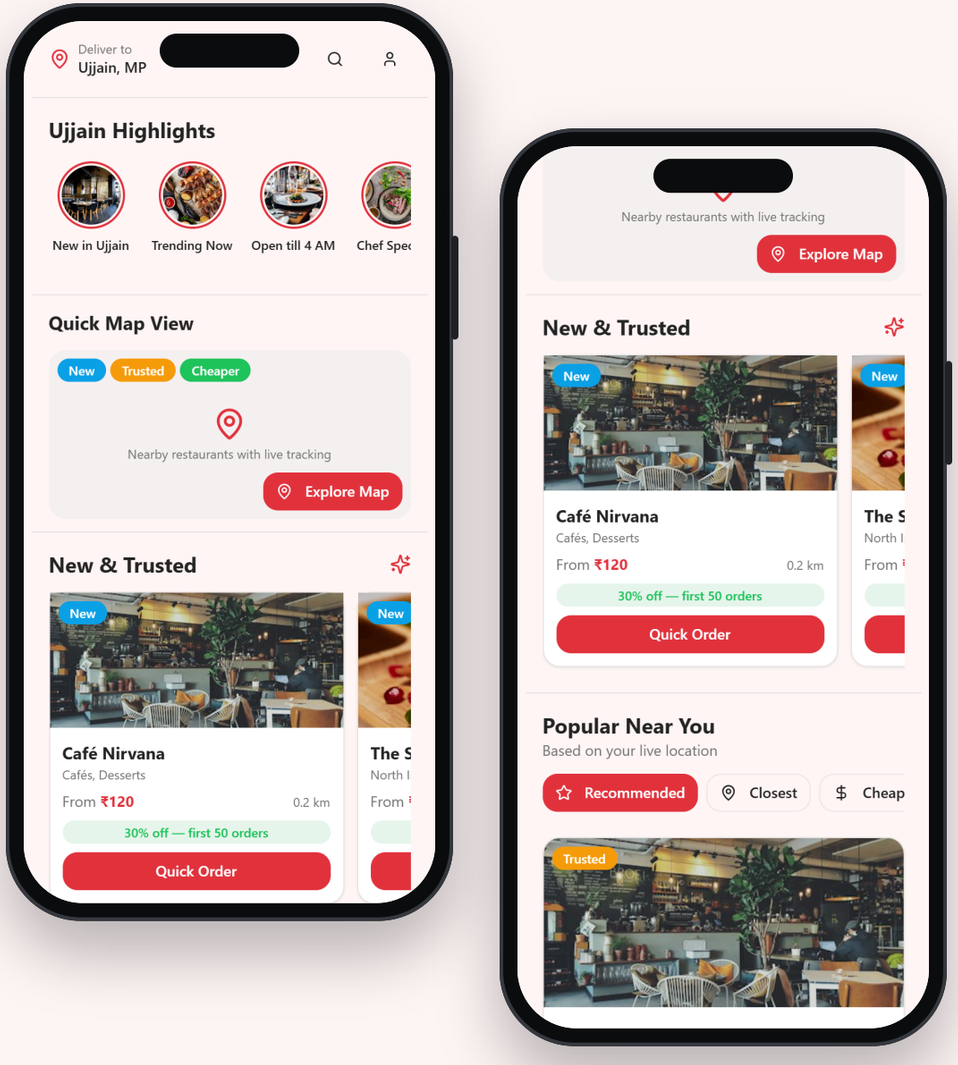
Case Study: zomato

Result: 1st Runner-Up, pan-India competition

Goal: Boost orders for new and small restaurants

Later: Built into a live prototype

Author: Godhuli Vyas



The problem: good food, zero visibility

zomato

The default sort on a food delivery app rewards restaurants that already have volume. **More orders bring more ratings, more ratings bring more visibility,** and a new listing starts every loop at zero regardless of food quality.

Cold start | Discovery | Retention | Hyperlocal

Key Insights:

For the restaurant: the first weeks are the hardest, exactly when low order volume hurts most.

For the platform: fewer new restaurants ever break through, so the marketplace narrows to whoever was already winning.

The fix is a second door, not a rewrite of the ranking.

Strategy: build a second door

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1

Trust, not stars

A "New - Verified" badge instead of an empty star rating, so no reviews reads as "just joined", not "unproven".

2

First-order economics

Front-loaded offers such as 30% off the first 50 orders or buy 2 get 1, paid by the platform for a short window.

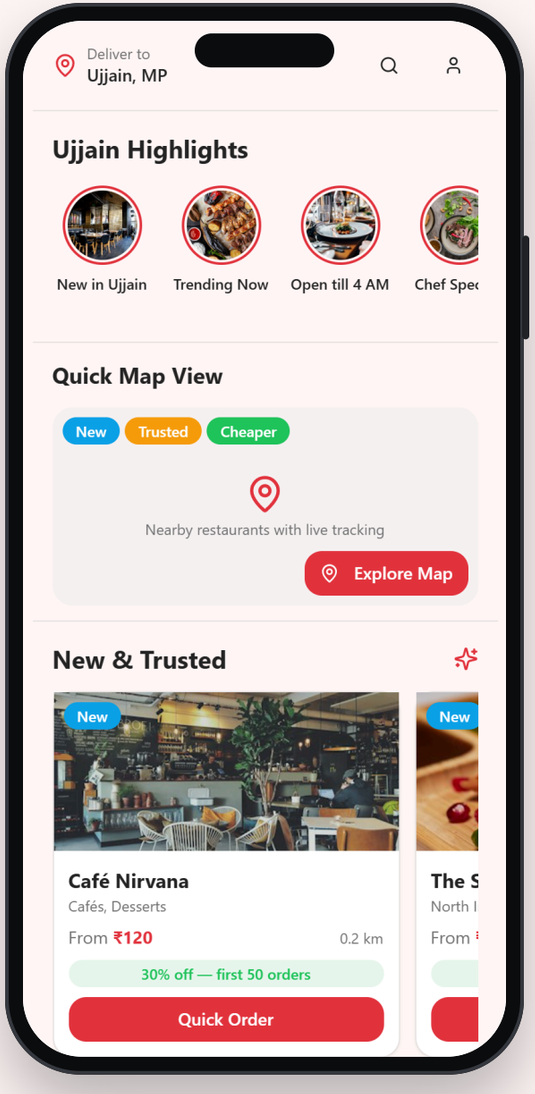
3

Hyperlocal framing

A city edition that surfaces late-night options, student-priced picks and local favourites.

Prototype: the home screen

zomato



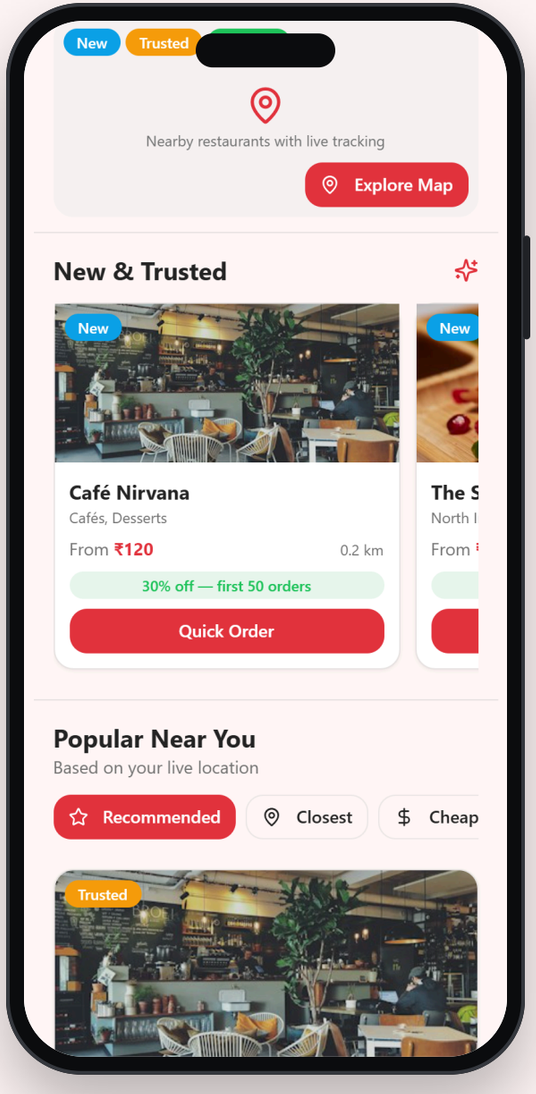
Highlights

Ujjain Highlights put New in Ujjain, Trending Now, Open till 4 AM and more at the top of the app.

The **New & Trusted row** sits above the default feed, not inside a filter menu.

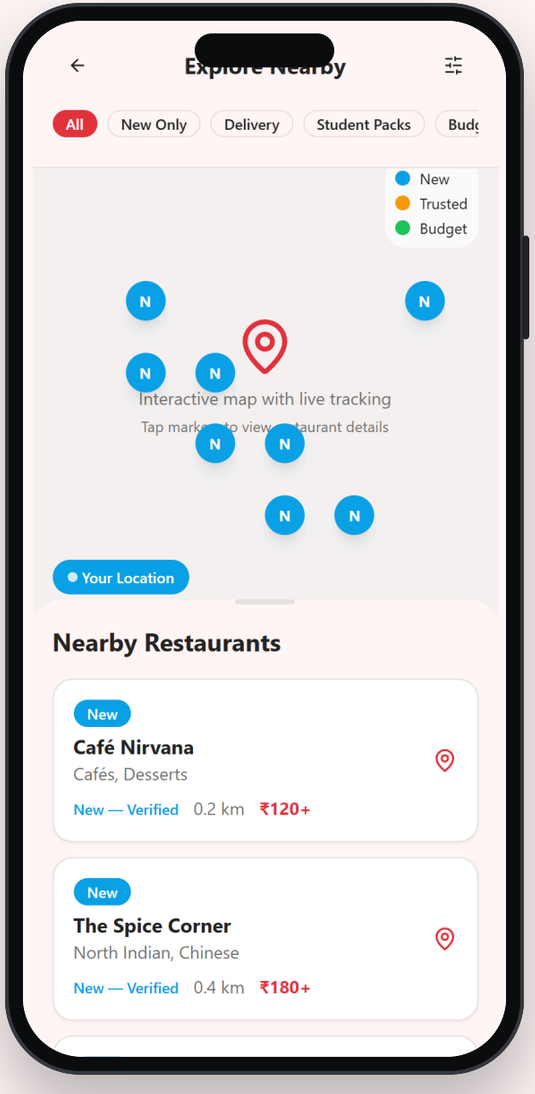
Each card carries a live first-order offer, for example **30% off, first 50 orders.**

Solution: The newest listings are the first thing a user sees, each with a reason to try it.



New & Trusted

Prototype: explore nearby



Explore Nearby

Filters include **New Only, Delivery and Student Packs,** matching the hyperlocal pillar.

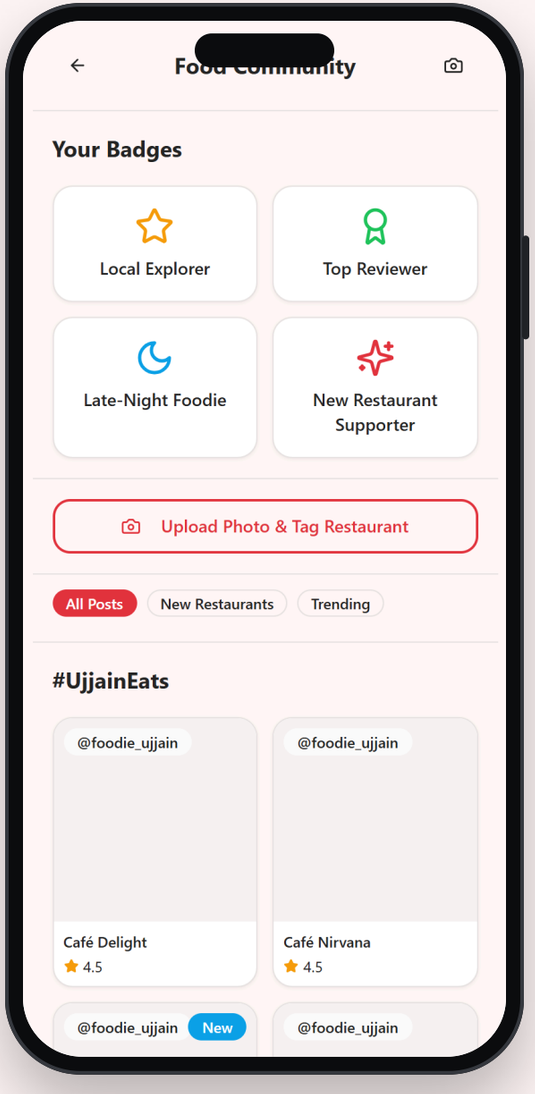
Map pins are colour-coded: **New, Trusted and Budget.**

Cards read **"New - Verified"** with distance and price, so a brand-new place still shows trust.

Solution: The badge turns "no reviews yet" into a clear signal.

Prototype: food community

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Food Community

Users **upload a photo and tag a restaurant** under #UjjainEats.

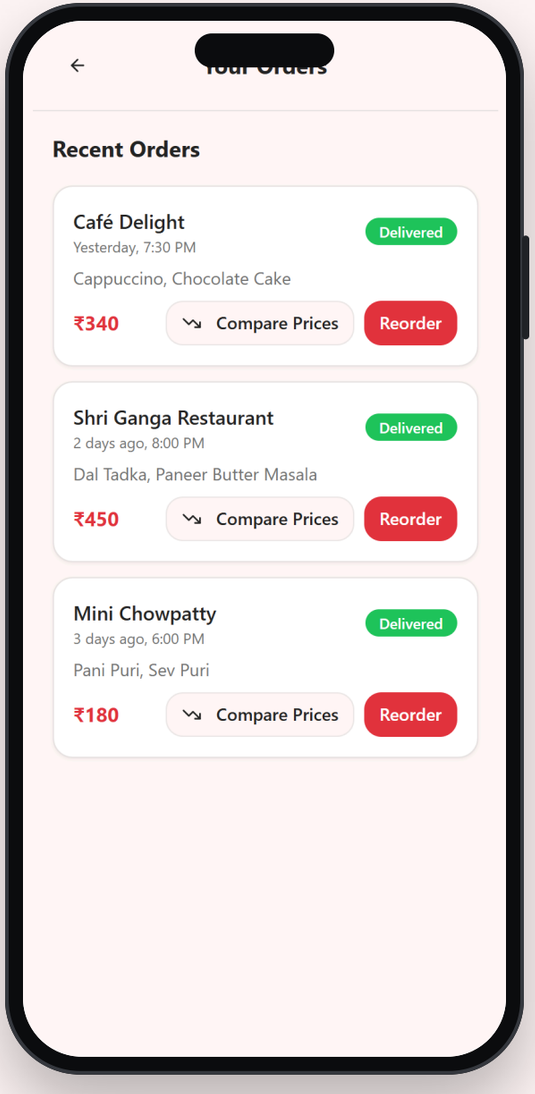
Badges reward the behaviour the strategy needs: **Local Explorer, Top Reviewer, Late-Night Foodie, New Restaurant Supporter.**

Early advocacy becomes a game, not a chore, which answers the missing-reviews problem.

Solution: A retention loop that lets people vouch for restaurants before the algorithm would.

Prototype: orders and price check

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Your Orders

Recent orders show a **Reorder** button for repeat purchases.

A **Compare Prices** action sits next to it, and cards in the feed note when cheaper options are nearby.

Repeat orders are what the first-order discount is meant to earn.

Solution: Repeat behaviour is the result that decides whether the offers pay off.

Why it placed, and the honest gap

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It reframed a ranking problem as a **discovery-surface problem.** The fix ships as a new section of the app, not a rewrite of how every restaurant is ranked.

Cold-start design | Discovery surface | Retention loop | Hyperlocal strategy

Key Insights:

Got right: it sidesteps rebuilding the core ranking algorithm entirely.

Want data on: whether the lift in repeat orders from a New & Trusted placement outweighs the margin given up in the first-order window.

Limit: the case study format could not test that number.

Proposed success metrics

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NORTH STAR METRIC

Repeat orders from new restaurants after the first-order window

Proposed by me, not measured. It tests whether the offers pay for themselves.

L1 METRIC

Share of orders placed from the New & Trusted row, and orders per new restaurant in its first weeks.

L2 METRIC

Community photo posts per active user and new restaurants tagged.

Thank you for reading.

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DISCLAIMER

An independent concept, not affiliated with Zomato. Screens are from my own live prototype, Zomato Ujjain Edition.
The success metrics are proposals, not measured results.

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